

2026 SEC CONFERENCE PRIMER

SOUTHEASTERN CONFERENCE

Conference outlook, tiers, projected order, schedule inflection points and team directory.

WHAT DEFINES THE 2026 SEC?

Two clear national-title-level rosters.

Two more top-10 caliber contenders.

A nine-game league schedule that can turn quality into losses.

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SEC AT A GLANCE

2026 CONFERENCE OVERVIEW

16 teams - 2026 preseason outlook

How to read the rankings: The **Primer power rating** estimates neutral-field team quality in points above or below an average FBS team. **Expected wins** is schedule-aware and reflects the full 12-game path. Those are intentionally different measures: a team can be stronger than another team while still projecting for fewer wins.

1. 60-Second SEC Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good is the SEC?	The deepest title-capable league in the project, with two clear championship rosters, two more top-10 contenders and almost no easy path through the middle. Georgia is the safest complete profile, while Texas may be nearly as good and still lose more games because of the schedule.
Title favorite	Georgia. The Bulldogs lead the SEC at +26.5 in Primer power and 9.9 expected wins , with the league's best combination of defensive star power, quarterback certainty and schedule survivability.
Best challengers	Texas, Texas A&M and LSU. Texas has the second-best underlying roster but the nation's No. 1 SP+ SOS. A&M pairs an established quarterback with major trench replacement. LSU has playoff-level talent but more newcomer and staff integration risk.
Best outside-crasher profiles	Oklahoma, Alabama, Tennessee and Ole Miss. Each has top-20 power and a plausible route into the race, but each also carries a major structural question at OL, QB, defensive continuity or schedule.
Biggest league-wide storyline	The nine-game SEC schedule turns roster flaws into record losses quickly. Texas, Oklahoma, Arkansas, Kentucky, Ole Miss and Florida all sit inside the national top 10 in SP+ schedule difficulty, so record alone will be a poor proxy for quality.
Schedule team to remember	Texas. The Longhorns rank second in SEC underlying power at +23.0 but only fourth in expected wins at 8.2 because SP+ rates the schedule No. 1 nationally .

Conference identity: The SEC has more teams with legitimate top-20 underlying quality than any other conference in the project, but it also has the least forgiving schedule environment. Georgia is the one team whose roster strength and schedule combine into a clean 10-win baseline. Texas, Texas A&M and LSU all look like playoff-caliber teams on a neutral field, yet each has enough schedule or roster-transition risk to make 8-4 or 9-3 fully compatible with elite quality. Below them, Oklahoma, Alabama, Tennessee, Ole Miss, Missouri and Florida form a dense upper-middle where quarterback certainty, line play and injury depth can swing multiple standings places.

Bottom line: Georgia is the SEC's safest championship bet on football quality, but the league is broad enough that a four-loss team could still be one of the country's 15 best teams. The central reading rule for this conference is simple: separate what a team is from what its schedule may allow it to look like.

Five things to remember

- Georgia and Texas are the two clearest championship-level rosters.** Georgia has the easier path; Texas has almost no margin for ordinary transition mistakes.
- Texas A&M and LSU are real top-10 contenders with different risks.** A&M must replace enormous trench volume, while LSU must make a newcomer-heavy offense and new staff structure cohere quickly.
- Quarterback certainty is uneven.** Arch Manning, Gunner Stockton, John Mateer, Marcel Reed, Trinidad Chambliss and LaNorris Sellers give several teams real stability, while Alabama, Tennessee, Florida, Missouri and the bottom tier enter with much wider QB outcome bands.
- There is no truly soft SEC schedule.** Even the relative schedule beneficiaries face repeated top-30 opponents, while Texas, Arkansas and Oklahoma draw three of the four hardest schedules in the country by SP+.
- The lower third is not hopeless, but the margin is tiny.** Auburn and Vanderbilt remain credible bowl teams, while Arkansas, Mississippi State and Kentucky need early role clarity because their schedules make late rescue jobs difficult.

2. Conference Power Structure

Tier	Teams	Read
Championship Tier	Georgia, Texas	Georgia has the league's most complete and stable profile. Texas is nearly as strong on a neutral field, but No. 1 SOS and more defensive/protection turnover make the record path much harsher.
Contender Tier	Texas A&M, LSU	Both are top-10 caliber. A&M's established QB/skill core is offset by huge OL/DL replacement; LSU's defense gives the new Kiffin/Leavitt offense time to settle.
High-End Spoilers	Oklahoma, Alabama, Tennessee, Ole Miss	All four can beat anyone in the conference. Oklahoma has QB/OC continuity and elite defense, Alabama has a playoff-level defensive ceiling, Tennessee has premium skill talent around a freshman QB, and Ole Miss returns an elite backfield.
Dangerous Middle	Missouri, Florida, South Carolina	These teams are good enough to punish contenders but carry enough transition or schedule risk to project closer to seven wins than ten.
Bowl-Line Tier	Auburn, Vanderbilt	Both have top-30 underlying quality and enough structure to reach six wins, but both are replacing high-leverage pieces in multiple position groups.
Bottom of the Table	Arkansas, Mississippi State, Kentucky	Each has a plausible development path, but low continuity plus top-12 national schedule difficulty leaves very little margin for early growing pains.

The SEC's defining feature is not simply that Georgia and Texas are strong. It is the amount of quality directly behind them. **Ten SEC teams carry a Primer power rating of +15.0 or better**, which means several teams projected around 7-5 or 8-4 would be favored over most of the country on a neutral field. The standings will compress that quality into losses because those teams repeatedly play one another.

3. Projected Conference Order

This is a schedule-aware projected order, anchored by expected overall wins and then adjusted editorially for team quality and uncertainty. It is not the underlying SEC power ranking.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
1	Georgia	9.9 wins - 10-2	+26.5	The SEC's most complete team, with a settled QB, elite defensive anchors and a difficult but survivable schedule.
2	Texas A&M	8.5 - 9-3	+21.0	Marcel Reed and the skill core create a contender floor, but replacing seven drafted linemen makes the trench rebuild decisive.
3	LSU	8.5 - 9-3	+20.5	Playoff-level talent and a strong defense, with the main risk concentrated in newcomer cohesion and offensive implementation.
4	Texas	8.2 - 8-4	+23.0	National-title quality can coexist with four losses because the Longhorns own the nation's No. 1 SP+ SOS.
5	Tennessee	7.9 - 8-4	+17.5	Elite supporting skill talent and a strong OL give true freshman Faizon Brandon an unusually good launch point.
6	Alabama	7.8 - 8-4	+17.5	The defense can keep Alabama in the race while Keelon Russell and a low-continuity offense learn on the fly.
7	Oklahoma	7.5 - 8-4	+19.0	The Sooners are stronger than seventh on a neutral field, but SOS No. 4 punishes every unresolved OL/RB issue.
8	Missouri	7.3 - 7-5	+15.5	A high-end run-game ceiling and quality line pieces keep the Tigers dangerous despite new QB/OC and defensive turnover.
9	Ole Miss	7.2 - 7-5	+16.5	Trinidad Chambliss and Kewan Lacy give Ole Miss real offensive star power, but the receiver/defensive reload meets SOS No. 8.
10	Florida	7.0 - 7-5	+15.0	Deep skill talent and a strong defensive core create upside, while QB proof, OL uncertainty and SOS No. 9 keep the range wide.
11	South Carolina	6.5 - 7-5	+12.5	LaNorris Sellers and Dylan Stewart are premium anchors, but OL/WR attrition and SOS No. 13 make the record path unforgiving.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
12	Auburn	6.4 - 6-6	+11.5	Byrum Brown raises the offensive ceiling, but transfer-heavy reconstruction in both lines makes early cohesion essential.
13	Vanderbilt	6.3 - 6-6	+10.0	The program floor is higher, but replacing Diego Pavia plus four OL starters makes 2025's 10-win breakthrough a poor baseline.
14	Mississippi State	4.7 - 5-7	+5.0	Kamario Taylor gives the offense a stable center, but OL uncertainty and another defensive rebuild limit the margin.
15	Kentucky	4.5 - 4-8	+4.5	New staff, Kenny Minchey and useful line anchors provide a plan, but SOS No. 7 makes bowl eligibility a real accomplishment.
16	Arkansas	4.4 - 4-8	+5.5	The Razorbacks should improve, yet a new staff, unproven QB and massive churn collide with the nation's No. 2 SP+ SOS.

The most important divergence is **Texas and Oklahoma**. Texas is the SEC's No. 2 power team but only fourth in expected wins; Oklahoma is No. 5 in power but seventh in expected wins. The inverse is smaller but still meaningful for **Texas A&M and LSU**, whose schedule paths allow their projected records to sit slightly ahead of where pure neutral-field ranking would place them.

4. The Title Race

The SEC title race begins with four teams that have legitimate playoff-level profiles, then expands into a second group capable of disrupting the bracket without requiring a full-season breakthrough.

Georgia - the safest complete profile

Georgia is the conference favorite because it combines the SEC's best **Primer power rating (+26.5)** with the strongest schedule-adjusted projection at **9.9 wins**. Gunner Stockton, Nate Frazier and a decorated OL core give the offense continuity even while the receiver hierarchy changes. The defense has an unusually strong returning spine in KJ Bolden, Ellis Robinson IV, Raylen Wilson and a deep front.

The failure mode is narrower than for the other contenders: the passing game never finds enough explosive separation, the offensive tackle transition becomes a recurring problem, and accumulated defensive departures reduce depth later in the year. Georgia can survive one of those issues. It probably cannot afford all three against an SEC schedule that becomes much denser after the October bye.

Texas - title quality, survival schedule

Texas may be the SEC's most important example of why record and team quality must be separated. The Longhorns rate **+23.0**, second in the conference, and Arch Manning plus Cam Coleman and Ryan Wingo create a genuine championship offensive ceiling. But SP+ rates the schedule **No. 1 nationally**, and the OL/defensive spine is less settled than the overall 71% returning-production number suggests.

The title case is simple: Manning becomes an elite efficiency/explosiveness engine, the OL stays healthy and Colin Simmons leads a defensive reload that is merely good rather than dominant. The failure mode is equally clear: a strong team gets ground down by repeated top-20 opponents before the new protection and back-seven structure fully stabilizes.

Texas A&M - established quarterback, rebuilt trenches

A&M's **+21.0** power rating and **8.5 expected wins** fit a playoff contender. Marcel Reed gives Mike Elko a known quarterback around Mario Craver, Terry Bussey, Rueben Owens II and Isaiah Horton, while the veteran safeties provide defensive structure.

The question is whether a contender can replace **seven drafted linemen** plus additional front-seven losses without losing the efficiency that made 2025 work. Four OL jobs are new, the defensive front is transfer-heavy, and the final five games include Alabama, South Carolina, Tennessee, Oklahoma and Texas. A&M can win the league if the new lines become average quickly; if not, the schedule is designed to expose the weakness late.

LSU - ceiling over certainty

LSU has **+20.5** power, **8.5 expected wins** and one of the league's best defensive floors. Sam Leavitt, a deep skill group and Trey'Dez Green give Lane Kiffin and Charlie Weis Jr. enough talent to create a high-end offense, while Blake Baker retains Whit Weeks and another talented defensive reload.

The title risk is cohesion. A new offensive ecosystem, newcomer-heavy roster and unsettled right side of the OL create more implementation variance than the top-10 model signal suggests. LSU does not need immediate perfection because the defense can carry September, but the offense must be fully functional before the November Alabama-Texas-Tennessee run.

The outside crashers

Oklahoma may be the best team outside the top four: John Mateer and Ben Arbuckle provide rare QB/OC continuity, and the defense still has an elite ceiling. The problem is SOS No. 4 and a C+ OL projection. **Alabama** has enough defense and receiver talent to reenter the title race if Keelon Russell becomes a reliable first-year starter behind a rebuilt line. **Tennessee** gives true freshman Faizon Brandon premium RB/WR support and an experienced OL, but the league rarely offers patience to a first-year quarterback. **Ole Miss** returns Trinidad Chambliss and Kewan Lacy, yet replacing major receiver, safety and front-seven production while playing SOS No. 8 lowers the floor.

5. Teams Most Likely to Be Better Than Their Record

The SEC has several teams for whom an ordinary-looking record could hide very good football. This is a schedule effect more than a pessimistic team evaluation.

Oklahoma

Oklahoma is the clearest example. The Sooners rank **fifth in SEC power (+19.0)** but only **seventh in expected wins (7.5)** because SP+ SOS is **No. 4 nationally**. John Mateer and Ben Arbuckle give the offense a stable organizing point, and the linebacker/secondary core supports another strong defense. An 8-4 Oklahoma team could still be one of the country's 12 to 15 best teams if the losses come during a schedule that includes Michigan, Georgia, Texas and a brutal closing run.

Ole Miss

Ole Miss sits **eighth in SEC power (+16.5)** but only ninth in expected wins at **7.2**. Chambliss and Lacy are strong enough to keep the Rebels dangerous every week, and the OL has useful continuity. The problem is that the receiver and defensive reload meets a schedule featuring LSU, Texas, Georgia and Oklahoma. Seven wins would be disappointing relative to recent program results, but it would not automatically mean the underlying team fell out of the national top 20.

South Carolina

South Carolina's **+12.5** rating is a legitimate top-25 signal, yet only **6.5 expected wins** come with SP+ SOS **No. 13**. Sellers gives the offense a high-end quarterback floor and Dylan Stewart can anchor a disruptive defense. The weak point is the reworked offensive line and receiver group. If those units become merely competent, the Gamecocks can play much better than a 7-5 record would suggest.

Florida

Florida is another candidate to look better on film than in the standings. The Gators rate **+15.0** with a deep skill group and strong defensive pieces, but SOS No. 9 plus limited QB starting proof and OL uncertainty create a volatile path. A 7-5 result can coexist with real top-20 quality if Aaron Philo develops quickly and the losses cluster against Texas, Georgia, Oklahoma and Florida State.

6. Teams Whose Record May Run Ahead of Their Power

This section is subtler in the SEC because almost nobody owns a truly favorable schedule. The useful distinction is relative: which teams have a record path that is a little cleaner than similarly strong peers?

Texas A&M

A&M ranks **third in SEC power** and **second in expected wins**. That is not a major disconnect, but it matters in a league where Texas and Oklahoma are pushed down by much harder slates. Three opening home games and a mid-October Citadel reset give the new lines time to develop before the late contender gauntlet. A 9-3 record would be fully earned, but it should not automatically place A&M above Texas in a neutral-field ranking.

LSU

LSU ranks **fourth in power** but tied for **second in expected wins**. The schedule is still hard, yet two non-Power home games and an October bye before the Alabama-Texas-Tennessee stretch give the new offense useful installation windows. If LSU reaches 9-3 while Texas finishes 8-4, the standings could tell a different story than the underlying team-quality board.

Missouri

Missouri is a modest version of the same idea. The Tigers rank **ninth in SEC power (+15.5)** but eighth in expected wins at **7.3**. The early schedule offers time for Austin Simmons and Chip Lindsey to settle before the late Texas-Georgia-Kentucky-Oklahoma stretch. If Ahmad Hardy returns quickly and the rebuilt defense stabilizes, eight wins are plausible without requiring Missouri to become a true top-six SEC team.

7. The Bottom of the Table

The lower SEC is especially harsh because the schedules do not provide many escape routes. Auburn and Vanderbilt still have legitimate bowl-level quality, while Mississippi State, Kentucky and Arkansas need their transition pieces to work early enough to survive a schedule that gets less forgiving as the season goes.

Auburn and Vanderbilt - bowl teams with different transition problems

Auburn has the strongest underlying profile in this group at **+11.5**. Byrum Brown is a meaningful quarterback upgrade and already knows the imported offensive structure, Jeremiah Cobb provides backfield continuity, and Xavier Atkins anchors a credible linebacker unit. The risk sits in the places that usually determine whether a transfer-heavy rebuild works: OL cohesion, WR role clarity and defensive-front replacement. Auburn can get comfortably beyond 6-6 if those groups settle before the Tennessee-Georgia-LSU-Ole Miss stretch, but the schedule will not let the Tigers hide a bad line.

Vanderbilt is a different kind of regression case. The program itself appears healthier after a 10-win breakthrough, but the exact offense that drove 2025 is gone. Blaze Berlowitz starts the opener with Jared Curtis also expected to play, four OL starters must be replaced, and the edge/secondary groups also turn over. The veteran linebacker core gives the defense a floor. A return to 6-6 would look like a major statistical decline while still representing a program that has clearly raised its baseline.

Mississippi State - quarterback stability, everything around it

Mississippi State has one of the bottom tier's most useful starting points in returning QB Kamario Taylor. Jeff Lebby's offense also has Fluff Bothwell, Anthony Evans III and C Canon Boone, so the Bulldogs are not starting from zero. The problem is structural: four OL jobs remain unsettled, the defense is being reshaped again under Zach Arnett, and SP+ SOS No. 12 leaves few clean opportunities. Five wins is a reasonable baseline; bowl contention requires the OL to stabilize faster than expected and the defense to stop giving away explosives.

Kentucky - a coherent reset with almost no schedule margin

Kentucky at least enters the new Will Stein/Joe Sloan structure with clear OL anchors in Lance Heard and Coleton Price, while Kenny Minchey has been named the starter. Jay Bateman's aggressive defense has enough pieces to be functional. But the roster is low-continuity at QB, WR, secondary and edge, and SP+ SOS **No. 7** is unforgiving. Kentucky does not need to become a bad program to finish 4-8; it simply needs a normal Year 1 adjustment period against a schedule that rarely gives one.

Arkansas - improvement can still finish last

Arkansas may be better than the 2-10 team it replaces. KJ Jackson has won the QB job, Tim Cramsey brings a defined offensive system, and Quincy Rhodes Jr. gives the defensive front a proven disruptor. Yet this remains a massive staff/roster reconstruction with an unproven quarterback and rebuilt OL, linebacker and secondary groups. Add SP+ SOS **No. 2**, and the Razorbacks can improve substantially without escaping the bottom of the standings. The season is best judged by whether the new offense becomes functional and whether the defense establishes a sustainable Year 1 identity.

8. Quarterback Landscape

Quarterback is one of the SEC's biggest separators because the league contains both some of the country's most stable high-end starters and several contenders asking new quarterbacks to survive elite defenses immediately.

QB tier	Teams	Read
Established high-end advantage	Texas - Arch Manning; Georgia - Gunner Stockton; Oklahoma - John Mateer; Texas A&M - Marcel Reed; Ole Miss - Trinidad Chambliss; South Carolina - LaNorris Sellers	These teams enter with the clearest combination of established QB1 status, system support and proven Power Four production. That certainty matters enormously in a nine-game SEC schedule.
High-upside transitions	LSU - Sam Leavitt; Alabama - Keelon Russell; Tennessee - Faizon Brandon; Missouri - Austin Simmons; Florida - Aaron Philo	The talent is sufficient for strong seasons, but each team has a wider outcome range because the quarterback is new to the role, system or full-season responsibility.
Defined but still proving it	Auburn - Byrum Brown; Vanderbilt - Blaze Berlowitz/Jared Curtis; Arkansas - KJ Jackson; Mississippi State - Kamario Taylor; Kentucky - Kenny Minchey	Brown brings useful system familiarity, Taylor brings returning-starter stability, and the others have clearer roles than they did earlier in camp. None has enough proof to erase the surrounding roster questions.

Three situations have disproportionate influence on the title race. **Keelon Russell** does not need to become a superstar if Alabama's defense remains elite, but he must avoid making the offense a weekly liability. **Faizon Brandon** gets one of the league's best support environments for a true freshman, with DeSean Bishop, Braylon Staley, Mike Matthews and an experienced OL. **Sam Leavitt** has the highest immediate ceiling of the transition group, but LSU's new offensive ecosystem means quarterback performance and team cohesion are intertwined.

The middle and bottom offer a different lesson. **South Carolina and Auburn gain value because Sellers and Brown give transition-heavy rosters a defined center.** Mississippi State's Kamario Taylor does the same on a lower baseline. Vanderbilt, Arkansas and Kentucky do not need elite QB play to beat expectations, but they need competent early-down offense because their schedules make repeated three-and-outs especially costly.

9. Line-of-Scrimmage / Roster Continuity Themes

The SEC is a trench league in the most literal sense this year: several contenders have championship-level skill talent but unusually concentrated OL or defensive-front replacement risk.

Team	OL read	Defensive-front read	Why it matters
Georgia	A-, down	A-, stable	The Bulldogs have enough returning line quality to remain elite, but replacing first-round tackle talent and additional front contributors is the main structural risk in the league's best roster.
Texas	B+, stable	B+, stable	The grades remain strong, but health/final-five questions on offense and major LB/secondary turnover mean the line must help Arch Manning carry more of the weekly burden.
Texas A&M	B-, down	B, down	Seven drafted linemen plus additional front losses make A&M the contender most dependent on transfer cohesion in both trenches.
LSU	B+, up	B+, stable	Jordan Seaton raises the OL ceiling, while the front reload remains talented enough for the defense to carry early offensive transition.
Oklahoma	C+, stable	B+, down	The OL is the clear weak link on a team with top-15 QB/defense quality; a difficult schedule magnifies every protection problem.
Alabama	B-, down	B+, down	Keelon Russell's development depends on a line with two live competitions, while the defense must replace major front-seven production without losing its playoff-level ceiling.

Tennessee is the notable contender with the opposite shape: the experienced OL and elite RB/WR support make life easier for a freshman quarterback, while the defensive front is the more volatile side after heavy turnover and availability losses. **Ole Miss** has a B+ OL but must replace major defensive-front production. **Florida** has enough front-seven talent to remain disruptive but carries a much less settled OL.

The middle and bottom repeat the same pattern at lower talent levels. South Carolina has a proven quarterback and defensive star but a C-grade OL. Auburn is rebuilding both lines. Vanderbilt replaces four offensive-line starters and major edge production. Arkansas and Mississippi State both carry C+ OL projections, while Kentucky has a few useful OL anchors but substantial uncertainty elsewhere. In this conference, depth matters as much as the starting five because the nine-game schedule creates cumulative November stress.

10. Schedule & Swing Games

Relatively more manageable paths

There is no genuinely soft SEC schedule, so this is a relative category rather than a list of easy slates.

- **Georgia - SP+ SOS No. 26:** Still hard, but the league favorite gets two home warmups, an October bye and the SEC's cleanest combination of roster strength and schedule shape.
- **Vanderbilt - No. 24:** The schedule is difficult for a transition roster, but two nonconference home games and a late bye give the new QB/OL structure some breathing room.
- **Tennessee - No. 20:** Two early home evaluation windows and a bye after the first five-game SEC block help a true-freshman QB season develop in stages.
- **Alabama - No. 17:** The first five games contain only one SP+ top-25 opponent, giving Keelon Russell and the rebuilt offense time before Georgia-Tennessee-Texas A&M-LSU.
- **Auburn - No. 16:** Still difficult, but the schedule offers early stabilization opportunities before the brutal middle stretch.

Most demanding paths

- **Texas - SP+ SOS No. 1:** Ohio State plus Tennessee, Oklahoma, Florida, Ole Miss, LSU and Texas A&M creates almost no margin for a merely good week.
- **Arkansas - No. 2:** A rebuilding roster faces a schedule in which every project-team opponent is top-30 SP+, including five straight top-26 opponents to close.
- **Oklahoma - No. 4:** Michigan and Georgia arrive before Texas, and the Sooners close with Florida, Ole Miss, Texas A&M and Missouri.
- **Kentucky - No. 7:** A Year 1 staff and low-continuity roster must absorb a schedule loaded with top-30 SEC opponents.
- **Ole Miss - No. 8 and Florida - No. 9:** Both have top-20 underlying talent but enough transition that the schedule can turn small roster flaws into multiple losses.

Games most likely to shape the race

- 1 **Sept. 19 - LSU at Ole Miss** - an early test of LSU's new offensive cohesion against one of the league's best returning backfields.
- 2 **Sept. 26 - Oklahoma at Georgia** - Georgia's first major home SEC test and Oklahoma's chance to prove its top-15 quality can survive the OL question.
- 3 **Sept. 26 - Texas A&M at LSU** - a direct matchup between the two teams projected immediately behind Georgia in the standings.
- 4 **Sept. 26 - Texas at Tennessee** - the first SEC game in Texas's brutal path and a huge early stress test for Faizon Brandon.
- 5 **Oct. 10 - Georgia at Alabama** - the league favorite against the SEC's highest-variance brand-name contender.
- 6 **Nov. 7 - Alabama at LSU** - the opening game of LSU's defining Alabama-Texas-Tennessee November run.
- 7 **Nov. 14 - Texas at LSU** - two national-title-level talent profiles with very little late-season margin.
- 8 **Nov. 27 - Texas at Texas A&M** - rivalry stakes plus a potential direct sorting game for the SEC Championship and CFP picture.

The sequencing story is as important as raw SOS. **Texas** gets five of its first six games at home or neutral before November becomes heavily road-weighted. **A&M** gets a manageable early runway before its final five-game contender gauntlet. **LSU**

gets an October bye immediately before Alabama-Texas-Tennessee. **Georgia** gets its only bye before Florida-Ole Miss-Missouri-South Carolina. The teams that use those reset points best will have a major advantage in a league with almost no free Saturdays.

11. Teams to Watch

Alabama - how much can defense carry?

Alabama remains **+17.5** in power despite only 35% offensive returning production. That says a lot about the defensive ceiling and the remaining receiver talent. The 2026 question is not whether Alabama has enough good players; it is whether Keelon Russell, the rebuilt OL and a reshaped backfield can become functional quickly enough that the defense is not asked to win every contender game.

Tennessee - the freshman quarterback stress test

Tennessee has perhaps the SEC's best support structure for an inexperienced QB. DeSean Bishop, Braylon Staley, Mike Matthews and an experienced OL give Faizon Brandon legitimate help, while Jim Knowles adds defensive upside. If Brandon is merely efficient, Tennessee can beat the 8-4 baseline. If he plays like a freshman against SEC pressure packages, the same roster can get dragged back toward the middle.

Missouri - the late-season trap team

Missouri has a clear downhill identity, quality tackle/TE pieces and a defense that should remain structurally sound even after substantial turnover. Ahmad Hardy's opener absence is a short-term issue rather than a season thesis. The larger question is whether Austin Simmons and Chip Lindsey can punish loaded boxes before the Texas-Georgia-Kentucky-Oklahoma run arrives.

Florida - dangerous before dependable

Florida has enough skill talent and defensive upside to beat teams above it in the standings. Aaron Philo is now QB1, but he has limited starting proof and the OL remains unsettled. If the passing-down offense improves, the Gators can be a top-20 team in substance even against a top-10 schedule. If not, the volatility will show up quickly.

South Carolina - premium anchors, thin margin

Sellers and Stewart give South Carolina two of the league's most important individual anchors, but the roster around them is less settled. The OL is heavily reworked, the receiver hierarchy is thinner, and the schedule becomes relentless after mid-October. South Carolina can be much better than a 7-5 record, but only if the offense becomes more sustainable rather than asking Sellers to solve every high-leverage down.

Vanderbilt - regression without returning to the basement

A 10-win repeat is not the right standard. The useful question is whether Clark Lea's program can replace the specific Pavia-led offense, rebuild four OL jobs and stay bowl-relevant. The veteran linebacker core and raised program floor make that plausible. Six wins would be a large numerical regression without erasing the broader progress.

12. Team Primer Directory

For the full roster, coaching, unit-grade, player and schedule breakdowns, open the individual team primers:

Team	Full 2026 team primer
Georgia	Georgia 2026 Preseason Primer
Texas	Texas 2026 Preseason Primer
Texas A&M	Texas A&M 2026 Preseason Primer
LSU	LSU 2026 Preseason Primer
Oklahoma	Oklahoma 2026 Preseason Primer
Alabama	Alabama 2026 Preseason Primer
Tennessee	Tennessee 2026 Preseason Primer
Ole Miss	Ole Miss 2026 Preseason Primer
Missouri	Missouri 2026 Preseason Primer
Florida	Florida 2026 Preseason Primer
South Carolina	South Carolina 2026 Preseason Primer
Auburn	Auburn 2026 Preseason Primer
Vanderbilt	Vanderbilt 2026 Preseason Primer
Arkansas	Arkansas 2026 Preseason Primer
Mississippi State	Mississippi State 2026 Preseason Primer
Kentucky	Kentucky 2026 Preseason Primer

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